

THE COMPLAINT SIGNAL

Reading our consumer complaints as an early-warning system.

What 1.28 million complaints reveal about our standing, our risk, and our next move.

#1

Most-complained company
in the United States

20.8%

Of our resolutions get
disputed by the consumer

+78%

Complaint surge before
the 2017 breach disclosure

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Four findings, one mandate:

treat complaints as a priority signal.

01

We lead the wrong table

115,703 complaints — the single most-complained-about company in the entire CFPB database, ahead of every bank.

02

We resolve, but rarely fix

Only 15.8% of our cases end in any relief vs Experian's 40.3%. We are fast on the clock, soft on the outcome.

03

Disputes signal legal risk

20.8% of our resolutions are disputed by the consumer — nearly double Experian's 11.7%. That is litigation exposure.

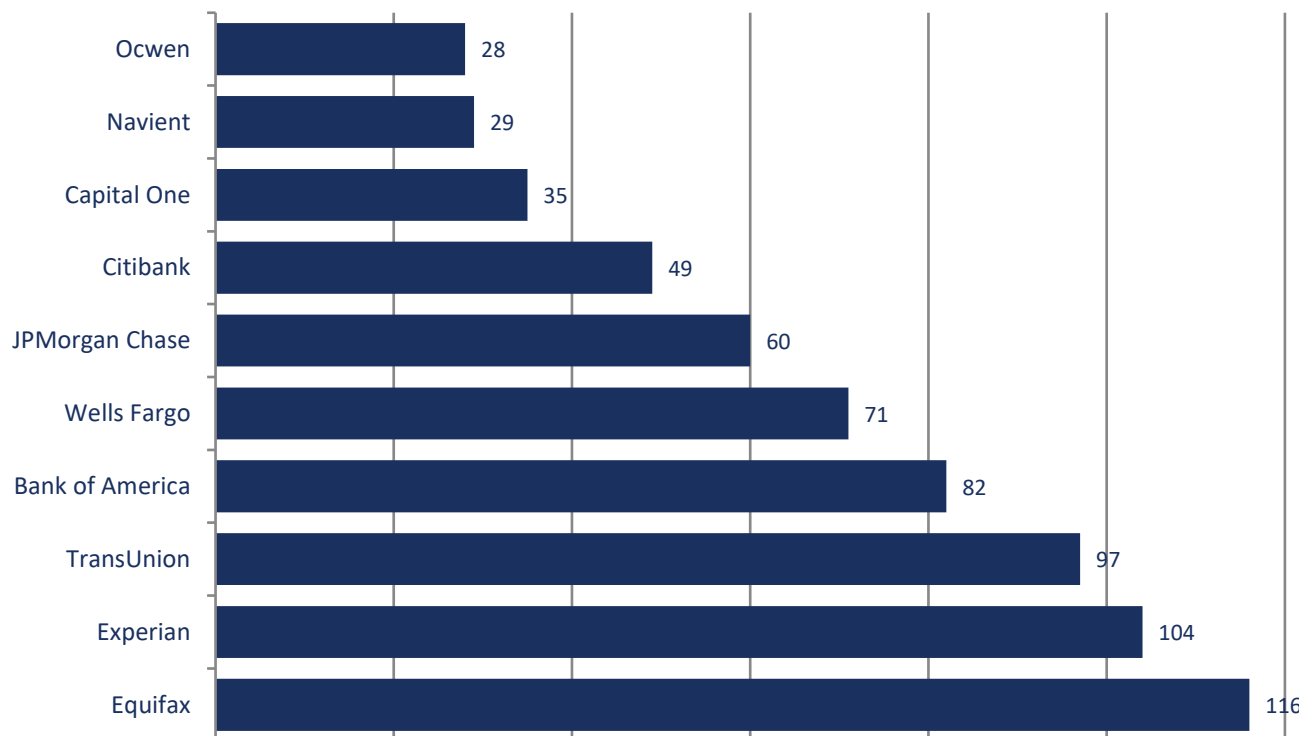
04

The breach was pre-signalled

Complaints climbed +47% to +78% for four months before the Sept 2017 disclosure. The signal was in our own data.

THE PROBLEM

We are the most-complained-about company in America.



Equifax leads with 116K complaints — 12% above #2 Experian.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The three credit bureaus occupy the top three spots — together ~25% of all complaints in the database.

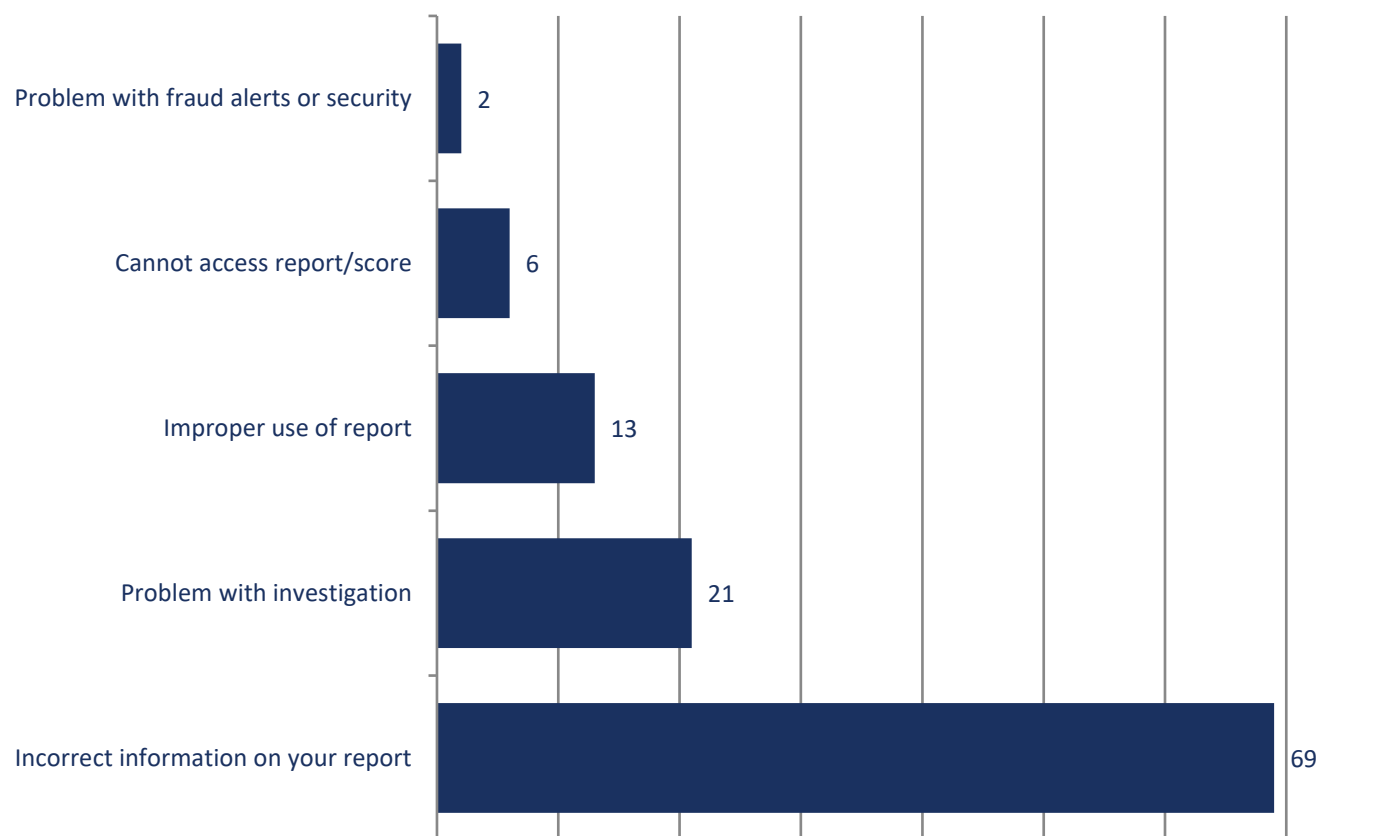
12%

more complaints than Experian, the #2 company.

Complaint share is effectively a public benchmark — regulators and litigators read this table too.

ANATOMY OF THE COMPLAINTS

Almost all of it is one thing: credit-report accuracy.

**~95%**

of complaints concern report accuracy, investigations, or improper use.

85%

arrive through the web intake form — a single, automatable channel.

38,203

carry a free-text narrative — a ready-made corpus for NLP.

OUR RESPONSE PROFILE

We answer fast — but we rarely fix the problem.

98.6%

Timely response

We hit the regulator's clock almost every time.

80.3%

Closed with explanation only

The default outcome: a letter, not a correction.

15.8%

Any relief granted

Monetary relief is effectively 0%. We seldom make the consumer whole.

THE TRAP

'Closed with explanation' looks like the cheap default — but 1 in 5 of those consumers come back and dispute it. Speed is a compliance metric; resolution is the trust metric, and that is the one we are failing.

PEER ANALYSIS

The only fair benchmark is the other two bureaus.

Equifax, Experian and TransUnion do the identical job, answer to the same regulator, and operate on the same consumer data. Comparing us to a bank is noise — comparing us to them is the mirror.

US

Equifax

115,703

total complaints

Rank #1 of 3 by volume

PEER

Experian

103,784

total complaints

Rank #2 of 3 by volume

PEER

TransUnion

96,587

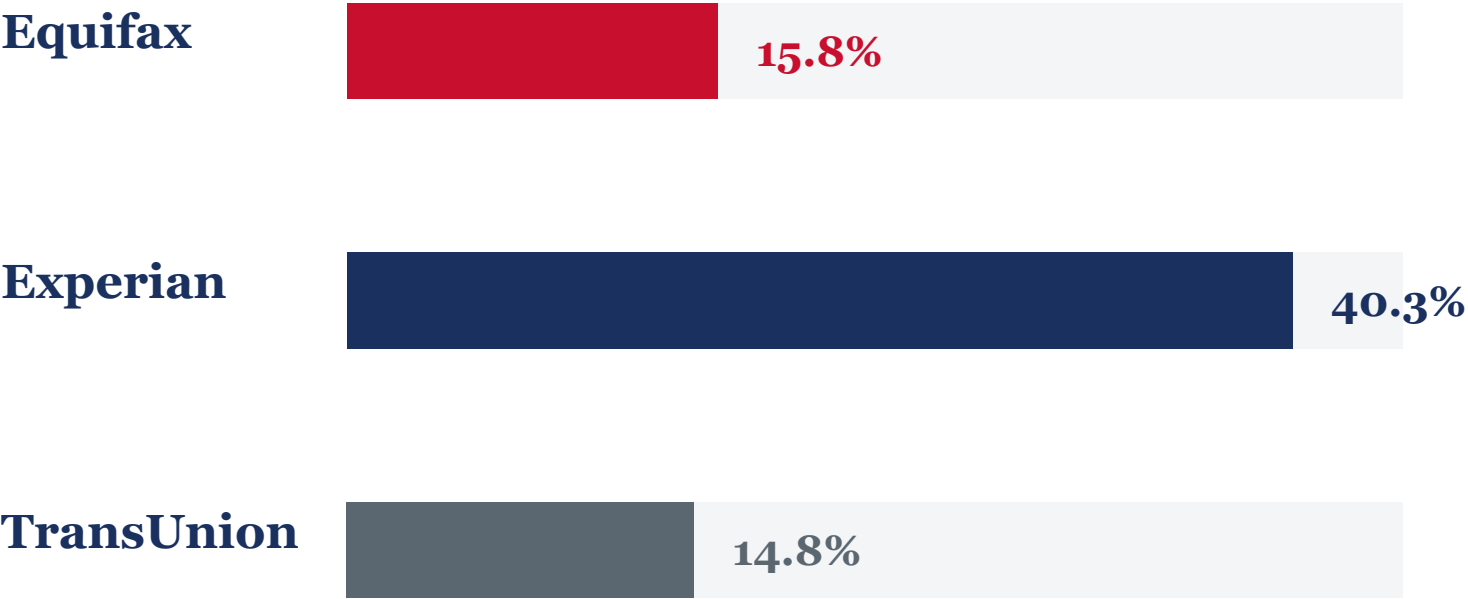
total complaints

Rank #3 of 3 by volume

Volume alone is the easy story. The harder — and more damaging — gaps show up in how each bureau resolves, which the next two slides isolate.

PEER ANALYSIS • RESOLUTION QUALITY

Experian fixes problems 2.6× more often than we do.



Any relief granted (%)

THE GAP

15.8%

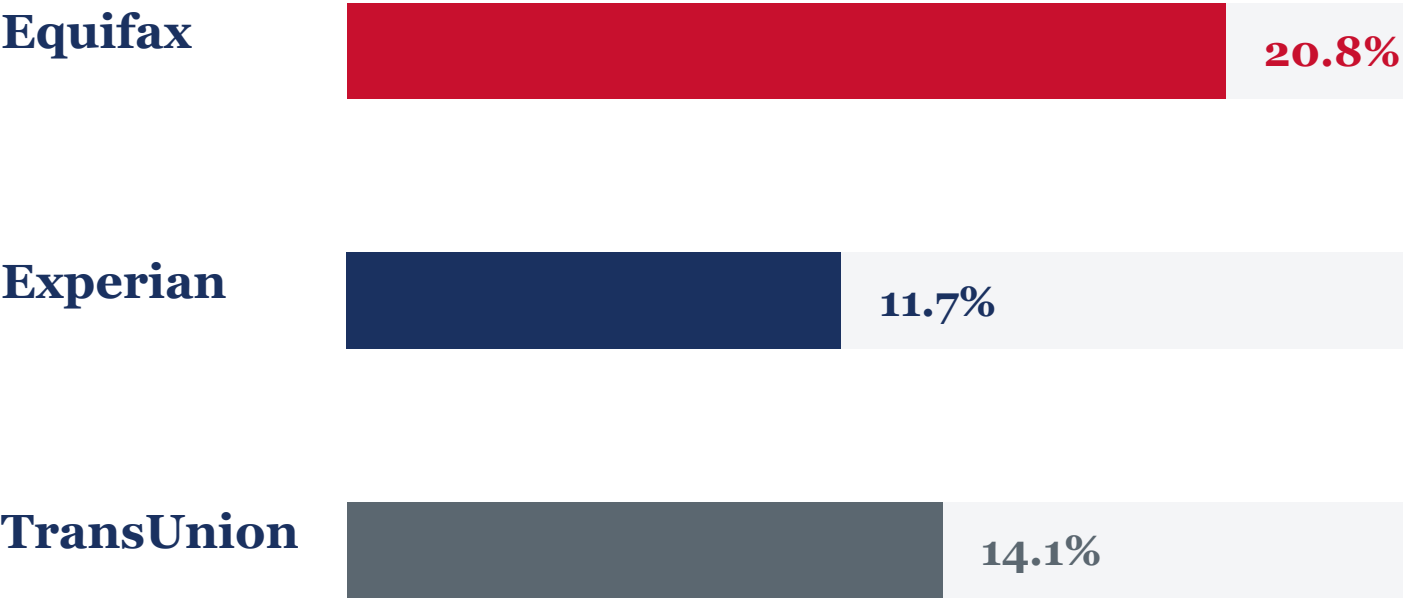
of Equifax complaints end in any relief.

40.3%

Experian's relief rate — the benchmark we should be chasing.

Same data, same rules — a behavioural choice, not a structural limit.

Consumers dispute our resolutions twice as often.



Consumer dispute rate (%)

THE LEGAL TELL

Dispute rate is the lagging indicator of resolution quality — and the leading indicator of litigation.

+78%

higher dispute rate than Experian (20.8% vs 11.7%). Every disputed close is a customer primed to escalate, churn, or sue.

PEER ANALYSIS • SCORECARD

Where we stand: behind on every metric that builds trust.

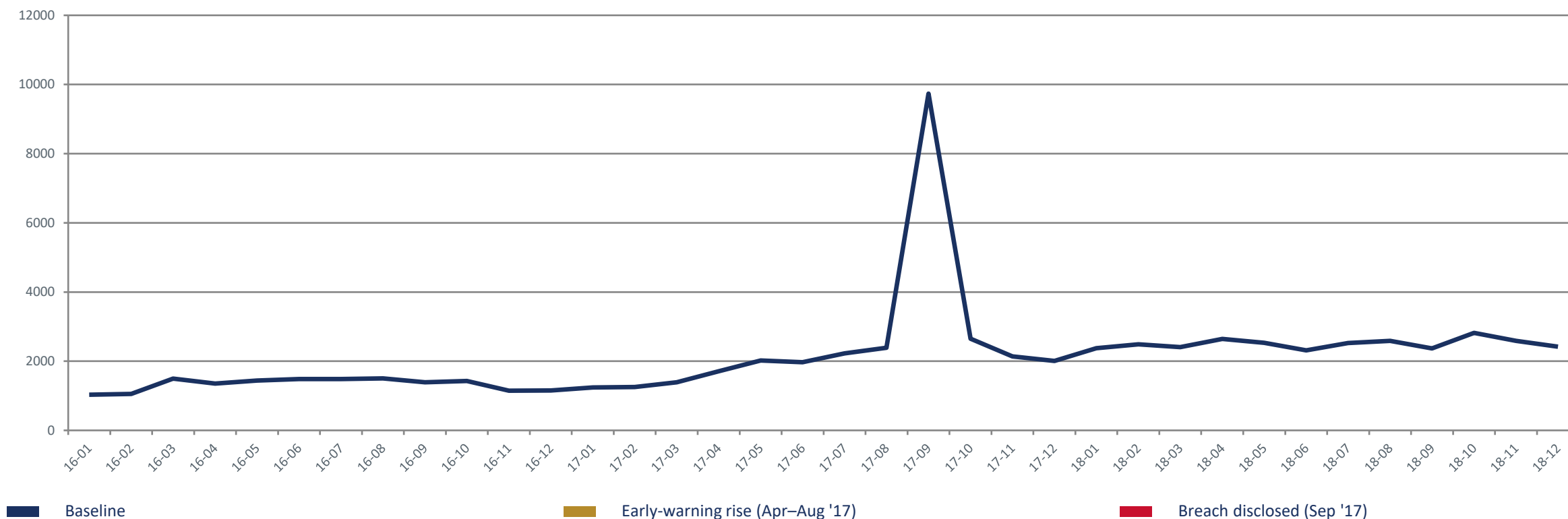
Metric	Equifax	Experian	TransUnion	Our standing
Complaint volume	115,703	103,784	96,587	Worst (#1)
Timely response	98.6%	99.99%	99.9%	Worst
Any relief granted	15.8%	40.3%	14.8%	2nd
Consumer dispute rate	20.8%	11.7%	14.1%	Worst

THE VERDICT

Last among the three bureaus on volume, timeliness and dispute rate, and we trail Experian badly on relief. None of these gaps are structural; all are addressable.

THE 2017 BREACH • IN OUR OWN DATA

The breach has a complaint signature — and it started early.



9,736 complaints in September 2017 — a 5.5× spike over baseline. But notice the four amber months before it: the rise was already underway.

THE THESIS

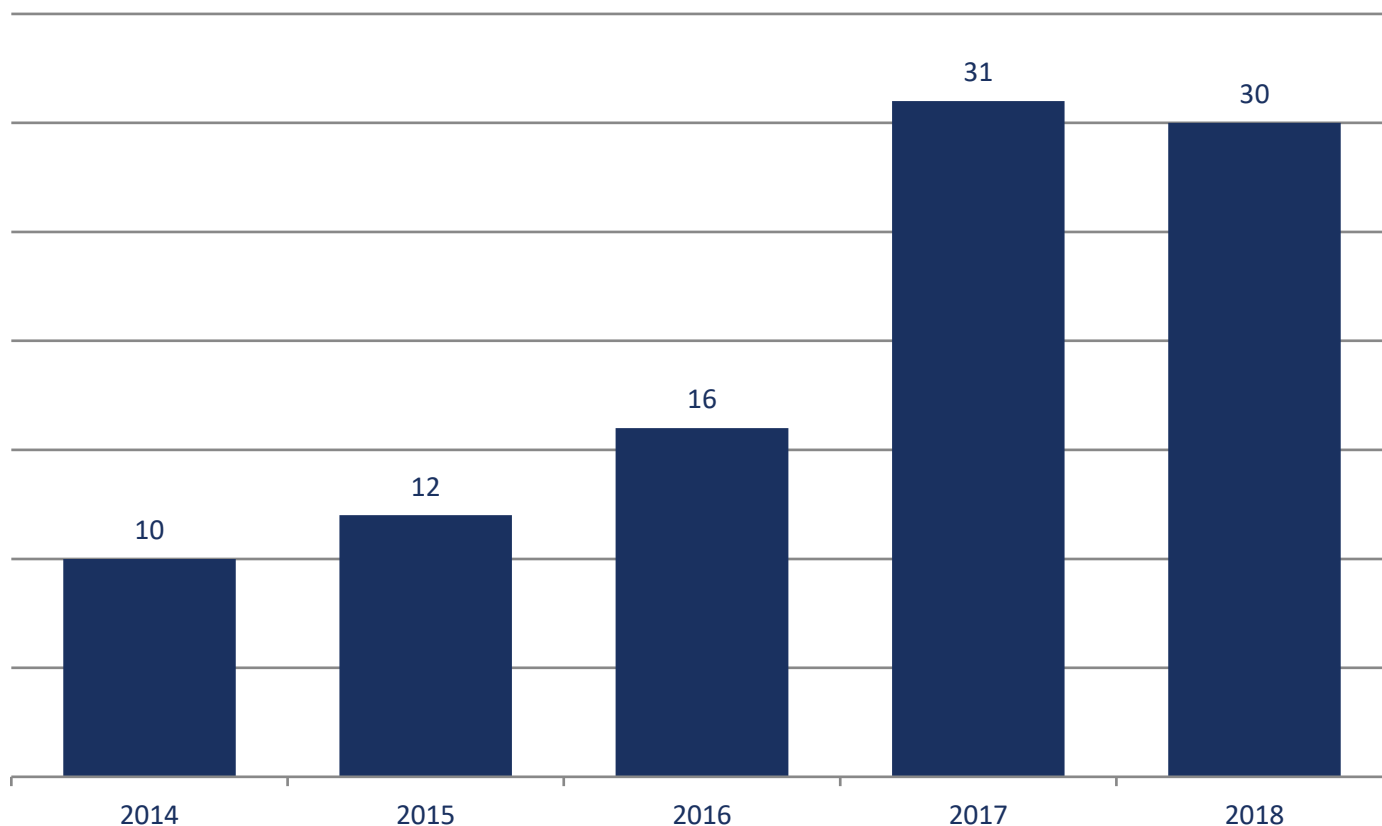
The signal was in our data four months early.

**WHAT THIS MEANS**

A simple anomaly-detection model on monthly complaint velocity would have flagged the abnormal rise weeks before disclosure. Complaint volume is a real, leading risk indicator — and today nobody is watching it.

THE LASTING COST

The breach permanently doubled our complaint baseline.



+92%

jump in annual complaints from 2016 to 2017.

It never came back down.

2018 held at ~30,000 — roughly double the pre-breach level. The reputational shock became a permanent operating cost: more cases, more staffing, more scrutiny, every year since.

RECOMMENDATIONS • OPERATING MODEL

Fix how we handle complaints — before any algorithm.

Five operating changes we control directly — no technology required.

1**Investigate — don't just explain**

Open a real root-cause review on accuracy and investigation cases, instead of defaulting to “closed with explanation.”

2**Make report accuracy the priority queue**

It is ~95% of our volume: staff it accordingly, tighten SLAs, and fast-track repeat or systemic errors.

3**Measure resolution, not just speed**

Add an internal relief-rate target benchmarked to Experian — timeliness alone is not success.

4**Pre-screen high-risk closures**

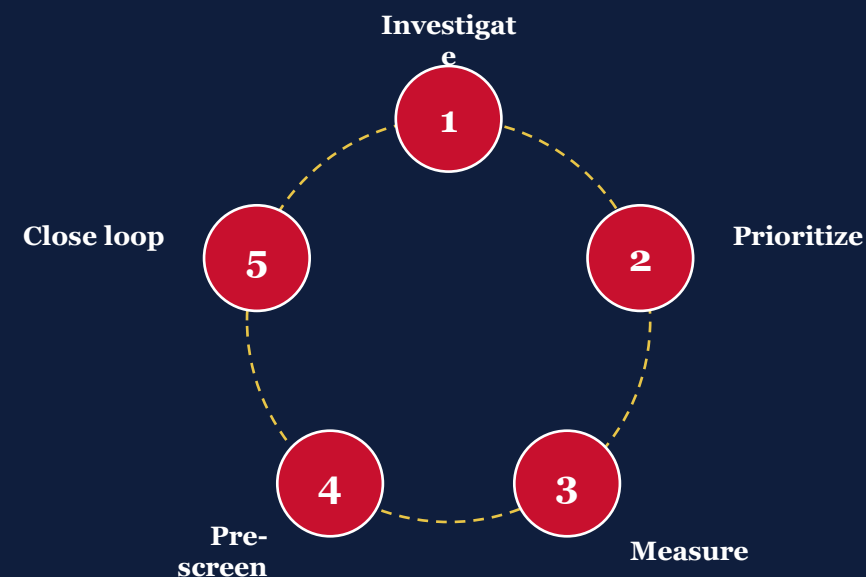
Flag complaints likely to be disputed or escalated for senior review before the response goes out.

5**Close the loop to data quality**

Feed recurring complaint root-causes back to the data pipeline so the same errors stop recurring.

THE OPERATING LOOP

Every closed case feeds the next.



THE OPPORTUNITY • AI

Then layer AI on top — three systems, one rollout.

01

Early-warning radar

Anomaly detection on daily complaint velocity — flags abnormal spikes like the 2017 rise and alerts risk & security in near-real time.

02

Narrative triage engine

NLP on the 38K+ free-text narratives to auto-classify issue, severity and root cause — faster routing, systemic defects surfaced.

03

Resolution-quality model

A dispute-risk score that flags closures likely to be contested, so high-risk cases get real remediation up front.

ROLLOUT

Now*0–3m*

Pilot the early-warning radar on historical complaint data.

Next*3–9m*

Deploy triage + dispute-risk scoring into the live intake workflow.

Later*9–18m*

Wire radar into enterprise risk; report complaint-health to the board.

THE ASK

Stop treating complaints as a cost. Start reading them as a signal.

01

**We are #1 — and last
where it counts.**

Most complaints in the U.S., worst peer dispute rate,
half Experian's fix rate.

02

**The signal predicted the
crisis.**

Complaints rose 47–78% for four months before the
2017 disclosure, unwatched.

03

**The fix is data we already
own.**

Early-warning radar, narrative triage, and dispute-risk
scoring — no new data needed.

SAME JOB · SAME REGULATOR · SAME DATA

A 2.6× gap on actually fixing problems.

All three bureaus answer on time. Only one is meaningfully fixing the problem.



SPEED — A SOLVED PROBLEM

Untimely response rate

1.41%	0.01%	0.09%
Equifax	Experian	TransUnion

All under 1.5% — responding on time no longer tells the bureaus apart.

RESOLUTION — THE REAL GAP

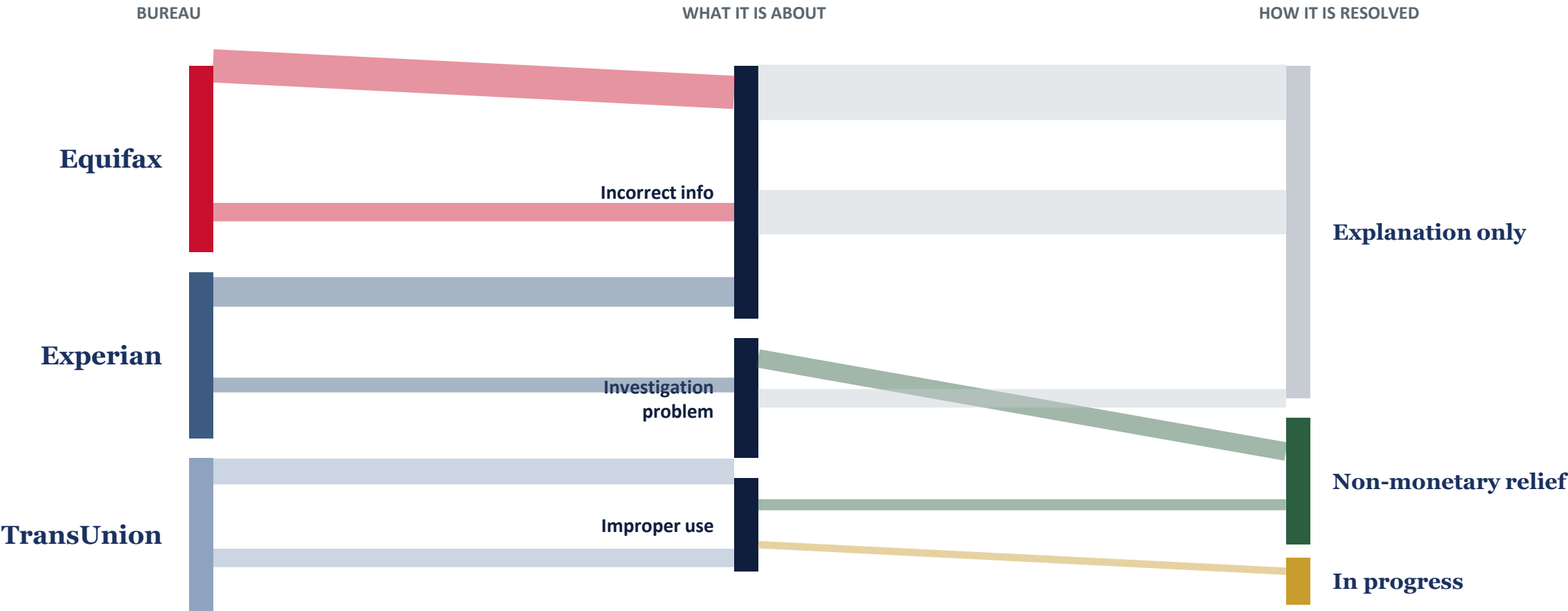
Any relief granted

40.3%	15.8%
Experian	Equifax (us)

2.6× more often Experian actually fixes the problem — on identical data and rules.

THE WHOLE STORY · ONE DIAGRAM

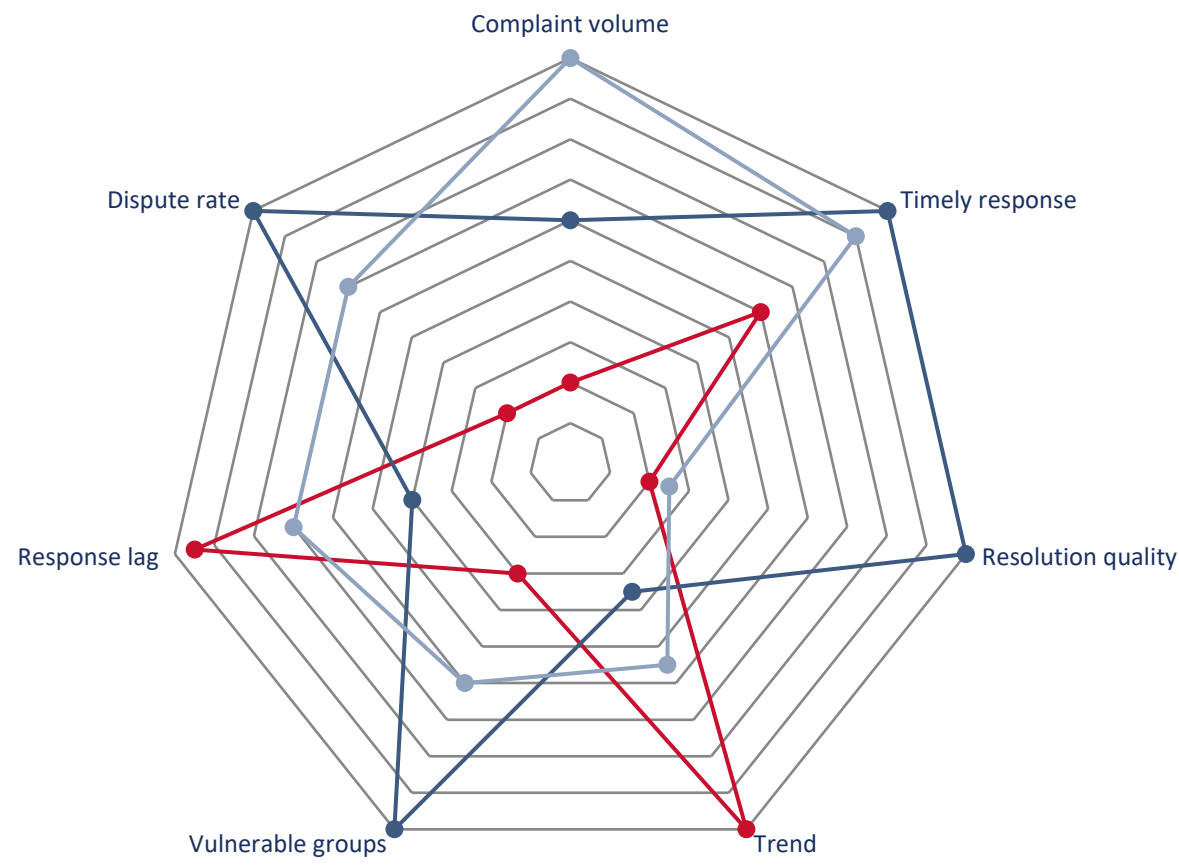
Every complaint flows the same way: into "explanation only."



Read it in two moves: all three bureaus converge on **Incorrect information**, and the dominant outcome is **"explanation only" (grey)** — the no-fix close. The green **non-monetary relief** flow is the actual fix, and Experian's green ribbon is visibly the thickest.

7-dimension Bureau Accountability Index.

COMPOSITE SCORE (0–100, higher = better)



1

Experian

74.3 /100

Leads on resolution quality, timeliness, dispute rate and vulnerable-group relief.

2

TransUnion

50.6 /100

Lowest raw volume and fast, but weakest on resolution quality.

3

Equifax

43.6 /100

Best on trend recovery and routing speed — trails on the consumer-outcome axes.